



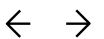
Closings and Delays

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TIMELINE: Here's what we know about the disappearance and death of 18-year-old Nolan Wells



The disappearance and death of Nolan Wells



1:56

Nolan Wells autopsy raises new questions; friend on island with Nolan July 4 speaks out

3:01

Nolan Wells cause, manner of death 'undetermined' after independent autopsy report

1:20

Preliminary results of independent autopsy find Nolan Wells' cause of death to be 'undetermined'

1:12:37

FULL PRESS CONFERENCE: Ben Crump announces Nolan Wells preliminary independent autopsy findings

3:55

Remembering Nolan Wells: Loved ones gather to honor his memory

By [Cody Heaster](#), [Will Polston](#) and WLOX Staff

Published: Jul. 6, 2026 at 9:19 PM CDT | Updated: 8 hours ago





In the days after Nolan's death, his family hired attorney Ben Crump, whose team is conducting an independent investigation after they say "contradictions" in the case and lack of information from investigators concern them.

Nolan's cause and manner of death haven't been released. Results from an independent autopsy requested by Crump's team and results from the original autopsy conducted by the Mississippi State Medical Examiner's Office are not yet available.

Jackson County investigators initially said they suspect that Nolan drowned, but they are still searching for answers and continuing the investigation.

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From press conferences pushing for transparency, to discussion about racial dynamics in the U.S., to social media speculation and AI-generated photos and videos circulating online, the case has gained national attention and is continuing to develop each day.

Here's what we know so far about the timeline of events leading up to Nolan's discovery and the aftermath in days following.

Friday, July 3

Nolan's mother, Christine Wonsley, said the last time she heard from Nolan was on July 3. He cooked dinner for his parents before heading to a friend's house where he was staying the night.

Nolan said, "Hey mom, I'm about to go, I love you," then gave her a kiss and hug before he left, Wonsley said.

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Saturday, July 4

Nolan traveled to Horn Island with a group of friends to celebrate Independence Day. The boat left from a private dock in the Ocean Springs area around 9:56 a.m., according to [data obtained by CBS from the Mississippi Department of Marine Resources \(MDMR\)](#).



Nolan and friends on a boat at Horn Island on the 4th of July. (WLOX)

According to that same data, the boat arrived at Horn Island at 11:14 a.m.

Nolan was last seen near the island around 3 p.m., according to the Jackson County Sheriff's Office (JCSO).

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Nolan's friends also said they last saw him around 3 p.m. on July 4 at Horn Island. Data obtained by CBS confirms the boat left the island at 4:31 p.m.

Nolan did not return on the same boat as the group.

"From what we understand, he chose to stay there," Sheriff Ledbetter told ABC.

Jackson County Chancery Judge Ashlee Cole is the stepmother of Warren, one of the boys who was on the boat with Nolan on July 4. Cole said Warren told her Nolan did choose to stay, and said the boys left early because the boat started having issues, taking in water.

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On July 16, ABC released audio recordings from July 4, where one of the teens on the boat can be heard calling a private towing company around 4 p.m., saying "We're sinking, can y'all please come?"

The dispatcher then said, "And is everyone on board and in good health otherwise?"

The caller responded, "Yeah, yeah, everyone is on board."



“They’re not saying the same thing,” Crump said. “One of them is telling the truth. One is not. We have to get to the bottom of that.”

Crump mentioned a video of an alleged argument on the island being circulated on social media, where he said Nolan can be heard saying, “Give me my freaking phone. What are you freaking doing?” When asked by a reporter in the crowd at the news conference how they knew it was Nolan’s voice, Crump said multiple people identified it as his.

However, on July 13, Tracestin Shepherd, a friend of Nolan’s, came forward and [told ABC that it was him](#) yelling in the video.

The Jackson County Sheriff’s Office has not confirmed the existence of a fight on the island, but they did ask anyone with video or images of an “alleged altercation” to reach out.

After leaving Horn Island around 4:30 p.m., data confirms that the boat traveled into Fort Bayou around 5:52 p.m., before returning to the dock at 6:06 p.m. It is unclear which parts of the trip the boat was towed.

Later that night, the boat went to the Fort Bayou boat launch at 7:19 p.m., was taken out of the water, and traveled over land to its owner’s home in Biloxi.

The Coast Guard told WLOX on Thursday, July 9, that a friend of Nolan’s contacted the agency around 11 p.m. the night of July 4. The Coast Guard would not disclose any other information about that call to WLOX, but said it “did not require Coast Guard assistance.”

Christine Wonsley said around 11:07 p.m., she got a call from Nolan’s friend Warren, who was on the boat with him. She didn’t elaborate on what was said during the call.

Wonsley said she then called her friend whose two sons are friends with Nolan and asked if they had seen him. They hadn’t, but they checked his Snapchat location.

Wonsley said she checked Nolan’s Life360 location, and it showed something completely different than Snapchat did: It showed his phone was back on land.

Wonsley said she made calls to local law enforcement around midnight, and after some “back and forth” between different agencies due to jurisdiction confusion with the island being out in the Mississippi Sound, the Jackson County Sheriff’s Office opened a report. Later that night, Nolan’s parents met a deputy in a McDonald’s parking lot and told them everything they knew at the time.

That night, Wonsley’s friend went to pick up Nolan’s phone from Nolan’s friend’s house, and Nolan’s father, Elmore Wonsley, went to get his car keys and car from a different friend’s home. The parents say they had “issues” getting these items back. See more details about that from the July 13 press conference [HERE](#).

When they got Nolan’s phone back, Christine Wonsley said she and her sister went through it. Wonsley said there were no photos and videos on Nolan’s Snapchat from that day, which is odd for him because he is usually capturing and posting everything. This led Christine to believe something may have been deleted.



The morning of July 5, Nolan's father Elmore Wonsley says he went to the island by boat with Nolan's football coach to search for his body.

At 12:26 p.m., Coast Guard Sector Mobile said it received a request for assistance from JCSO in search of a missing person in the vicinity of Horn Island. The Coast Guard said an urgent marine information broadcast was issued, and a helicopter was sent to search the area.

At 12:31 p.m., JCSO issued a press release saying it was searching for Nolan Xavier Wells, described as an 18-year-old Black male, approximately 6'1" and weighing 180 pounds. He was last seen on Horn Island on Saturday, July 4, wearing blue swim trunks, no shirt and sunglasses.

READ: [SEEN HIM? Authorities seeking information about Ocean Springs teen last seen on Horn Island](#)



Nolan Wells on July 4 (wlox)

At 5:54 p.m., JCSO established a command post at the Lake Mars Boat Launch.

Sheriff John Ledbetter said multiple agencies joined the search for Nolan, including the Gulf Islands National Seashore, U.S. National Park Service, U.S. Coast Guard, Mississippi Department of Marine Resources and Mississippi Department of Wildlife, Fisheries and Parks.

Other agencies joined in, including the Biloxi Fire Department, which had a boat out, the Harrison County Sheriff's Office, Jackson County Fire Service, and the United Cajun Navy.

Monday, July 6

United Cajun Navy aircraft took to the air just before 6 a.m. Monday.

Search boats were deployed again, with the last vessels leaving just before 8 a.m.



Horn Island (United Cajun Navy)

Around 8:45 a.m., Sheriff Ledbetter confirmed authorities received a call reporting a body found at the northwestern tip of Horn Island. The body was discovered by a U.S. Park Service ranger.

Nolan's family was asked to come to the Lake Mars Boat Launch, where they were met by Sheriff Ledbetter and Coroner Bruce Lynd.

Just after 11 a.m., the family was taken to the coroner's office in Pascagoula to identify the body.

Just before 1 p.m., Nolan's family confirmed his death on social media. His mother posted on Facebook confirming that Nolan was the person found on Horn Island.

READ: [Family identifies body found on Horn Island as 18-year-old Nolan Wells](#)

Tuesday, July 7

Just before 2 p.m., WLOX learned Nolan's family has retained nationally renowned civil rights and personal injury attorney [Ben Crump](#), calling for a thorough and transparent investigation into how Nolan died.

"Attorney Crump and the legal team will conduct an independent review of the circumstances of Nolan's death and will press for the timely release of all records, witness accounts, and autopsy findings," a press release by Ben Crump read.

Nolan's autopsy took place Tuesday at the Mississippi State Medical Examiner's Office Coast Lab.

Around 2 p.m. Tuesday, Coroner Bruce Lynd confirmed to WLOX News that the body found was Nolan, according to dental records.



or 228-769-3063 after hours.

[Authorities seek original photos, videos, eyewitness accounts related to Nolan Wells or 'unusual activity' on Horn Island July 4](#)

Tuesday at 9:15 p.m., Ashlee Cole made a [Facebook post](#), saying that her family is grieving with Nolan's family, and that she wanted to make a post to "dispel some rumors with facts."

Cole said she did initially deactivate her Facebook account due to fearing for the safety of herself and her family.

"We do not believe it is appropriate for our minor children's photographs to be circulated throughout the Internet, presenting potential threats to their safety," Cole said.

[Parent of Nolan Wells' friend, NAACP leader speak out about social media rumors](#)

Cole said she graduated high school with Nolan's mother and that they are "from the same community."

"I have the utmost respect for her and all of the Wells family," Cole said. "We mourn the loss of Nolan with them. Our prayers have been and will continue to be with them."

Cole also said her son last saw Nolan around 3 p.m. on July 4, before leaving the island at 4:30 p.m. when the boat they were on started having issues.

"Nolan made a decision to stay on the island and return inland later with another group of friends," Cole's post read.

Cole said her son has fully cooperated with law enforcement.



18h · 🌐

Our family, along with the community, grieves the loss of Nolan Wells. Our thoughts and prayers are with Nolan's family. Our son, Warren, loved Nolan dearly. Unfortunately, I feel that it is appropriate for our family to dispel some rumors with facts based upon the social media attention that is being diverted away from the Wells family and their loss.

Yes, I deactivated my Facebook. Given the very heightened emotional state of social media right now, I fear for the safety of my child and my children. My husband and I have six children and we covet their privacy. We do not believe it is appropriate for our minor children's photographs to be circulated throughout the Internet, presenting potential threats to their safety.

I graduated high school with Christine Wells-Wonsley. We are from the same community. I have the utmost respect for her and all of the Wells family. We mourn the loss of Nolan with them. Our prayers have been and will continue to be with them.

My husband and I were not at Horn Island at any point on 4th of July.

No one in our family is trying in any way to impede with the investigation by law enforcement or to otherwise hamper the family and law enforcement's quest for answers. Warren was interviewed by the Jackson County Sheriff's Department and cooperated fully. He saw Nolan last at around 3 pm on July 4th. They left around 4:30 pm when the boat was taking on water and they had an issue with the bilge pump. Nolan made a decision to stay on the island and return inland later with another group of friends.

Yes, I am a judge. I also value transparency. I apologize if anyone was offended that I deleted my social media. There were no nefarious motivations in my deleting my social media. Social media has a lot of positives, but a whole lot of negatives.

We live in a world of click-baiting. Sad, but true.

My family is hopeful that this information will help to redirect the attention to the Wells family, their grief, and their need for our community's support.

👍 1.8K 🔄 646



Ashlee Cole Facebook post (WLOX)

Jackson County NAACP President Curley Clark told WLOX News the NAACP is following the investigation closely to ensure no racial discrimination occurs, but he hopes people will not make their own conclusions before the investigation is through.

"The NAACP is going to ensure that the tragedy will be fully investigated," Clark said. "But we do not want anyone to jump to conclusions before the facts are known."

Wednesday, July 8

Attorney Ben Crump told ABC News Live Wednesday, sharing the family's concerns about South Mississippi law enforcement investigating a case of a "young Black man where young white students may be looked at as having some culpability."

[Attorney Ben Crump speaks to ABC News LIVE about Nolan Wells investigation](#)

Crump said that Nolan's body will be flown to Washington, D.C., for an independent autopsy. Crump also said investigators from his team are conducting interviews with witnesses.

Crump said results from the independent autopsy were expected Friday.



Thursday, July 9

Attorney Ben Crump sent a press release, revealing that a news conference was scheduled for 11 a.m. Central Time on Friday in New York, where he would call for “a full, transparent, and urgent investigation.”

Crump said he would be joined by Nolan’s family and Reverend Al Sharpton.

[Family of Nolan Wells to hold press conference with Ben Crump, Rev. Al Sharpton as independent autopsy ordered](#)

The night of July 9, Ashlee Cole made another Facebook post, revealing that she and her family were [receiving numerous death threats](#) online, posting screenshots of the threats. In the post, Cole says her family had not had the opportunity to speak with the Wells-Wonsley family or their attorney, but that they were willing to communicate directly with them.



July 9 at 10:25 PM · 🌐

We have decided that we will not be speaking to the press at this time.

The Media is not the appropriate forum to further elaborate on the facts of July 4, 2026. We realize that the truth will not stop the calls for the death of our small children.

We have not had the opportunity to speak to the Wells-Wonsley family or their attorney. However, we are willing to directly communicate with attorney Ben Crump and the Wells-Wonsley family.

We will provide them with all the information known to us so their family can rest and properly mourn.

We also want to know what happened to Nolan. We will do everything within our power to assist Nolan's family in their quest for answers.

yaeyae962 started following you. 19m

[Follow back](#)

yaeyae962 commented: Open up your insides 19m

♡ Reply

yaeyae962 commented: I got your email, your phone number, your address What's stopping... more 19m

♡ Reply

yaeyae962 commented: These two are gonna be strangled till their eyes go red an lips turn blue 20m

♡ Reply

yaeyae962 commented: Slow painful death 20m

yaeyae962
5 followers · 0 posts
Follows you

[View profile](#)

6:17 PM

There will be a package coming to your guys office in the next few days. It's gonna blow you away when you see it lol 🤔 probably best to have the boys there to see as well

Blood

So much blood everywhere

bro

So much blood everywhere

Hard to clean

Especially from a boat

But yours will be quick I promise

I got all you inof

Info

Not even the fbi can stop this

Once that package is opened the timer will start

And then you have maybe 10

Frankie Garcia 9:41 am

Ashlee Cole July 9 Facebook post (WLOX)

Friday, July 10

Nolan's parents, Christine and Elmore Wonsley [spoke to Good Morning America](#) alongside Crump.

The mother and father said they do not believe Nolan would have voluntarily separated from his group.

"We always taught him if you go with a group, you stay with the group," Elmore Wonsley said. "If you go with five, you come back with five. Do not separate from the group. He always said yes, sir. So he knew to stay with his group."

Later that morning, the family [held a press conference in New York](#) with Crump, and Reverend Al Sharpton.



During the hour-long press conference, the family detailed the moment they learned their son was missing and what followed.

Crump said the results from the independent autopsy in Washington D.C. were expected to be released Friday, but had been delayed due to canceled flights. Crump said his team will announce those results as soon as they have them.

Sunday, July 12

Nolan's mother, Christine Wonsley, once again called for anyone with information, photos and videos from Horn Island on July 4 to share it with [law enforcement and her legal team](#).

Monday, July 13

[On Good Morning America](#), Tracestin Shepherd, a friend of Nolan, addressed a viral video that investigators have been studying. Many worried the video showed Nolan in a confrontation, but Shepherd said that was not the case.

"That's the video I am referring to, and that's me yelling," Shepherd told Good Morning America.

Tuesday, July 14

After a previous conversation between Mississippi Coast Coliseum & Convention Center officials and Nolan's family regarding holding funeral services at the venue, officials announced Tuesday that the family would be going in a different direction.

Sam Voisin, the Coliseum's executive director, gave this statement:

On behalf of the Mississippi Coast Coliseum & Convention Center, we extend our deepest condolences to the family, friends, and all those mourning the loss of Nolan Wells.

After meeting with representatives of the Wells family, we support their decision not to hold Nolan Wells' funeral services at the Mississippi Coast Coliseum & Convention Center, Monday July 20th, as previously discussed.

We appreciate the opportunity to have worked with the family during this process and remain committed to supporting them and our community during this difficult time.



celebrate his life.

Jackson County District Attorney Angel Myers McIlrath told ABC News that she planned to meet Wednesday with Nolan's parents for the first time since his body was found.

DA McIlrath will ultimately decide whether the 18-year-old's death involved a prosecutable crime. Myers McIlrath said the meeting with the Wells family is meant to offer victim services and to help navigate the process of a death investigation. She routinely meets with families of deceased children.

Wednesday, July 15

Nolan's family and attorneys Ben Crump and Eric Hertz [met with Jackson County District Attorney](#) Angel Myers McIlrath Wednesday morning. Following the meeting, a press conference was held in front of the Jackson County Courthouse.



Crump said once the Jackson County Sheriff's Office investigation into Nolan's death is complete, the district attorney's office will present the case to a grand jury. That is standard procedure for most unnatural or suspicious deaths in Jackson County.

Crump also said that his team and Jackson County investigators will conduct a "mutual inspection" of Nolan's phone, which is in his team's possession.

Crump did not provide a timeline on the release of the independent autopsy results, which he initially said would be available last Friday. However, he said he hopes to share the results soon.

The family announced that Nolan's funeral services will be held on Monday at Center Pointe Church in Ocean Springs. Visitation will be from 9-11 a.m., and the funeral will begin afterward. A celebration of life will also be held at the Jackson County Fairgrounds following the funeral.

Following the news conference, a reporter asked about an image of an alleged [pool party circulating online](#) that Crump's page shared on Instagram.

Crump said his team is sharing anything and everything in order to get more people to come forward.

"Just because we repost does not mean we authenticate anything," Crump said.



The afternoon of July 15, Sheriff Ledbetter confirmed with WLOX that the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) is assisting his office with examining the digital evidence that's been collected so far. Ledbetter said this isn't out of the ordinary, as Horn Island is on federal land and the sheriff's office frequently works with the FBI.

The FBI told ABC that it is "working to address interstate threats that were received by individuals related to this matter."

The agency did not identify any of the recipients, but some people have stated publicly that they have received threats.

In addition to Ashlee Cole's post about receiving death threats online, Tracestin Shepherd told ABC News that he and other friends of Nolan's who were with him on the island have also received threats.

"It worries me for my friends. It worries me for my family," Shepherd told ABC News.

Sheriff Ledbetter also confirmed that over 60 witnesses have been interviewed at this point, including the three friends Nolan went out on the boat with.

The night of July 15, CBS released GPS [data of the boat's movements](#) on July 4 obtained by MDMR.

Thursday, July 16

ABC released audio recordings from July 4 when a teen on the boat with Nolan called a private towing company to report the boat was sinking.

Monday, July 20

A funeral service for Nolan was held at Center Pointe Church in Ocean Springs.

[Remembering Nolan Wells: Loved ones gather to honor his memory](#)

The Rev. Al Sharpton announced a \$50,000 reward for anyone who provides information leading to an arrest and conviction in the case. Actor Tyler Perry said he would match the reward, bringing the total to \$100,000.

Following the funeral, Christine Wonsley filed a court petition to be appointed as the administrator of her son's estate. This is a common legal action when someone has no children and the individual does not have a will.

The document outlines Christine Wells Wonsley as Nolan's heir and says that he "left an estate consisting solely of claims for damages resulting from the circumstances surrounding his death."

Tuesday, July 21

NFL Hall of Famer Terrell Owens said he is adding \$25,000 to the \$100,000 amount announced by Sharpton and Perry, bringing the total amount of reward money to [\\$125,000](#).

Attorney Ben Crump said he will announce the preliminary findings of an independent autopsy conducted on Nolan Wells on Wednesday, July 22, at the 117th NAACP National Convention in Chicago at 8 a.m.

Wednesday, July 22

At the NAACP National Convention, Attorney Ben Crump said Nolan Wells' cause and manner of death are undetermined "pending investigation," according to the preliminary independent autopsy report ordered by his team. He also said the date of Nolan's death is unknown.

[FULL REPORT: Nolan Wells cause, manner of death 'undetermined' after independent autopsy report](#)

Crump's team said the second autopsy was conducted by experienced forensic pathologist Dr. Roger Mitchell in Washington, D.C., on July 10. The report was created on July 19.

Because Nolan's body was so decomposed by the time the second autopsy was conducted, Dr. Mitchell couldn't tell if there were bruises or abrasions on his body, according to Crump.



Crump said there were organs missing when Dr. Mitchell received the body. Crump noted that it is common to remove organs when conducting an autopsy, especially if additional testing on specific organs is needed.

Because the throat was not received with the body for the second autopsy, Dr. Mitchell couldn't rule out injury to the neck as a contributor or cause of death. He also couldn't observe the airway for water or the stomach for gastric contents, according to Crump.

Crump said many questions still remain. Outstanding questions listed in the initial report from Dr. Mitchell are:

1. What were the circumstances that led to Nolan Xavier Wells entering the water?
2. What was the body position when found?
3. Was there water in the airway?
4. Is there any evidence of injuries to the anterior neck structures?
5. Is there any evidence of intracranial hemorrhage (subdural or subarachnoid)?
6. What was the composition of the stomach contents?
7. What are the toxicology report findings?

In an interview with ABC, Sheriff Ledbetter gave thanks to the public for sharing information and once again encouraged anyone who thinks they may have information to step forward.

"Previously, we put out a call to action for the public to come forward with any information that they may have pertaining to the Nolan Wells case, and that still stands as of right now. We're still asking for valuable, factual information that pertains to this case. Please come forward. Contact the sheriff's office. Even if you may think it's insignificant, every little bit helps, and it may be a bigger contribution than you think to this case."

If you have any information, contact JCSO at 228-769-3063.

Thursday, July 23



[Nolan Wells autopsy report to be withheld until grand jury review, district attorney says](#)

"Every death in the county—except those of natural causes and non-criminal car wrecks—is presented to your grand jury," McIlrath said in a video released Thursday. "Many people don't know that we have handled death investigations in this manner my entire career."

In her statement, McIlrath acknowledged the public's interest in the case, but said that investigators are already doing everything possible.

"The pressure for answers does not change what the work requires. Our responsibility to Nolan and our community is to complete this investigation thoroughly and carefully, without compromise—supported by the evidence and worthy of the confidence of the people we serve."

Remembering Nolan

Christine Wonsley said her son Nolan was "the kindest soul" who loved everyone and never met a stranger.

"Nolan is the funniest kid in our family," his father Elmore Wonsley said, adding that Nolan's siblings are hurting deeply.

At the July 10 press conference, both parents reflected on a touching story about a time they were in the middle of an argument, when Nolan ran into the room in his diaper and started dancing for them to ease the tension.



Nolan Wells and parents (WLOX)



Authorities are searching for 18-year-old Nolan Xavier Wells, who was last seen Saturday, July 4, around 3 p.m. on Horn Island, according to Jackson County Sheriff John Ledbetter. (wlox)

Nolan played football at Ocean Springs High School and Southwest Mississippi Community College.

On [National Signing Day in 2025](#), Nolan spoke to WLOX and called it a blessing to continue his football career at Southwest Mississippi Community College and to share the moment with his teammates.

“It’s truly a blessing being here with some of my best friends and teammates, and most of us are all going to college together. It’s just truly a blessing,” Nolan told WLOX on February 5, 2025.



Authorities are searching for 18-year-old Nolan Xavier Wells, who was last seen Saturday, July 4, around 3 p.m. on Horn Island, according to Jackson County Sheriff John Ledbetter. (wlox)



football player. He carried himself with humility, treated others with respect, worked hard and led by example. His character spoke louder than his accomplishments, and he was loved deeply by his teammates and coaches. Our football family is grieving alongside Nolan’s parents, family, friends, classmates, teammates and all who loved him.”

‘Loved deeply’: Nolan Wells remembered for lasting impact on South Mississippi community

“Nolan was a remarkable student, teammate and brother,” said Ocean Springs High School Principal Dr. Jacob Dykes. “He will be remembered as an extremely kind and hardworking young man who left a lasting impression on his teachers, coaches, teammates and community. Our thoughts are with his family and the many people he made a lasting impact on around him.”

“The entire Southwest family is heartbroken as we mourn the tragic loss of Nolan Wells,” said Southwest Mississippi Community College President Dr. J. Steven Bishop. “We remember Nolan as a well-respected young man who was very popular among friends, faculty, and staff. We loved Nolan, and he will be greatly missed in many ways. Our continued prayers will be with the Wells family now and in the days to come. Professional counselors and local ministers will be available to assist teammates and friends as they return to campus [Monday]. May God lead and guide all involved during this difficult time.”

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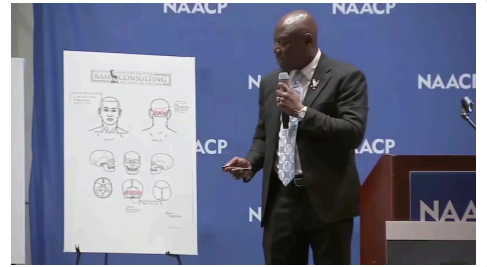
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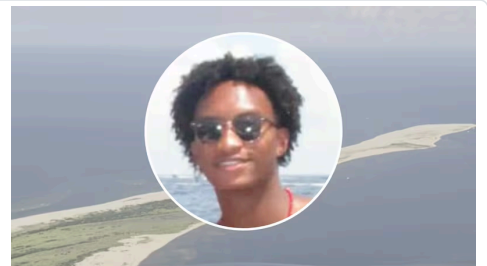
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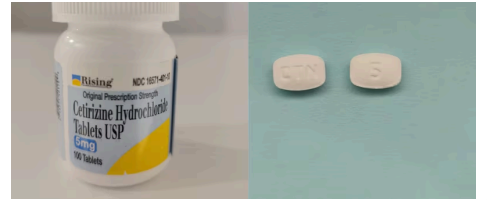
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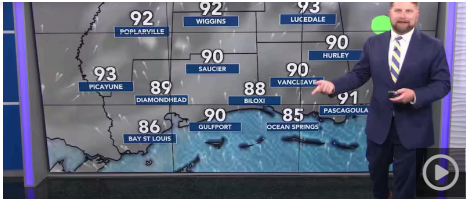


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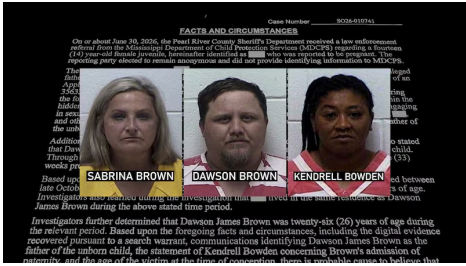
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